

**“Critical Analysis of Change Management at
Wakewood Building Supplies: A Strategic
Application of Kurt Lewin’s
Three-Step Model”**

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1. Introduction & Justification

1.1. Background of Case

The underperforming division of Wakewood Building Supplies, comprised of 700 employees and accounting for 20% of all business operations, is currently experiencing an important crisis in its performance due to increased operating expenses and high customer dissatisfaction levels (Wakewood Supplies, 2026) (Al Kuwari et al., 2026). Stagnation can be attributed to the fact that the unit does not respond to the needs of the 2026 construction industry with respect to automation and digitalization of operations (Wakewood Supplies, 2026). The underperforming division seems trapped in a “quasi-stationary equilibrium,” imposed on it by the GM through his cost-saving approach (Cummings et al., 2016).

1.2. Framework Selection

The three-step model by Kurt Lewin (MindTools, 2026) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026) forms the central analytical tool, along with Force Field Analysis (FFA), which will aid in providing an in-depth diagnosis of the forces keeping the unit in the status quo failure (MindTools, 2026). This is crucial, since the unit’s impediments stem from psychology; the chosen model emphasizes “unfreezing,” which entails fostering a state of “survival anxiety” and “psychological safety” to effectuate transition (Cummings et al., 2016) (Burnes, 2004). Through FFA, the driving forces, such as the 2026 technological revolution, will be mapped against restraining forces, including the GM’s management style and the employees’ apprehensions about employment stability (MindTools, 2026) (Al Kuwari et al., 2026).

1.3. Justification from a Metaphorical Perspective

The choice creates a link between GM’s “Machine Metaphor” and the CEO’s “Organism Metaphor” (Wakewood Supplies, 2026). While the GM sees the unit as a mechanism for minimizing costs (Cameron & Green, 2020), resulting in “organizational sclerosis,” due to rigid overhauls at a top-down level (Cameron & Green, 2020), the CEO sees Wakewood as a living system that needs to align with its 2026 environment through a participatory process of system well-being (Al Kuwari et al., 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020). Lewin’s change model brings these two together by making use of Organism as a basis for creating the “felt need” for change during Unfreezing, and Machine approach to “Refreezing” (Cummings et al., 2016) (Cameron & Green, 2020).

2. Evaluating Drivers for Change at Wakewood

2.1. Externally Driven Pressures: The Technological Paradigm for 2026

The construction world of 2026 has shifted from mere gradual changes to a more unstable VUCA environment as a result of fast technological development (Alayam News, 2026). World domination in the industry is now seen through the prism of Intelligent Building Automation worth \$157.62 billion and the adoption of technologies like Digital Twins, Cloud solutions, and IoT site visibility (Srivastava, 2026) (Fortune Business Insights, 2026). Thus, today's clients have come to expect complete clarity about processes and are in need of "proof, not promises," which stands in direct opposition to Wakewood's "Machine" model of management (Srivastava, 2026) (Johari et al., 2025).

2.2. Internal Trigger Points: Restraining Forces and the "Machine" Bottleneck

Internally, the unit suffers from strong restraining forces discovered using the Force Field Analysis model (MindTools, 2026) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026). The GM functions solely within the boundaries of the "Machine Metaphor," treating the 700 employees as interchangeable components whose sole purpose is to operate in an efficient and economical manner (Cameron & Green, 2020). In this way, the autocratic approach of the management has successfully killed the AR process - the spiral of planning, action, and investigation required for growth (Cummings et al., 2016) (Burnes, 2004). In addition, fear generated psychologically among employees regarding their future in the digital era has caused organizational sclerosis, making them defensive rather than adaptive (Cameron & Green, 2020). Additionally, this has created skill deficiencies because of the company's focus on cutting costs rather than investing in "Organism" training (Al Kuwari et al., 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020).

2.3. Deep Analysis of Drivers: The Quasi-Stationary Equilibrium

Crucially, the opposing driving forces help maintain a "quasi-stationary equilibrium," in which the driving forces of the CEO for growth are balanced out by the restraining forces of the GM internally (MindTools, 2026) (Hussain et al., 2018) (Cummings et al., 2016). This takes the form of the "Tension Paradox:" mere increase in the tension regarding technology implementation only serves to worsen the systemic problem, failing to facilitate movement

towards the desired goal (MindTools, 2026) (Cummings et al., 2016) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026). The culture in the organization is “frozen” on efficiency-based measures; rewards are geared towards immediate financial benefits instead of digital transformation (Al Kuwari et al., 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020). To overcome this equilibrium, the intervention plan needs to go beyond just analyzing the drivers and focus on “unfreezing” the system, reducing the restraining forces from above by the GM. This would allow the 700 employees to reach their potential and change into a digital future (MindTools, 2026) (Cummings et al., 2016) (Al Kuwari et al., 2026).

3. Analytical Critique of the Framework in Practice

3.1. Defining Core Attributes: The Four Pillars of Planned Change

The Three-Step Model of Lewin’s Unfreeze-Move-Refreeze should ideally be implemented through an appreciation of its synergistic relationship with Field Theory, Group Dynamics, and Action Research (Cummings et al., 2016) (Burnes, 2004). Currently at Wakewood, the GM’s view of planned change within the underperforming unit employs the metaphor of a “Machine” that needs its engine overhauled (Cameron & Green, 2020). Lewin’s three-step model, however, acts as a scientific method for challenging the quasi-stationary equilibrium maintained by the unit’s social system (Hussain et al., 2018) (Cummings et al., 2016). Field Theory represents the diagnostic pillar as an examination of the full set of “driving forces”—as the CEO’s expansion ambitions—counterbalanced against the “restraining forces”—including GM’s autocratic management style and worker fear of technology (MindTools, 2026) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026) (Al Kuwari et al., 2026). Group Dynamics recognizes the fact that the 700 workers are not just individual elements but rather follow a common code, which means that change efforts should be targeted at the group culture of the unit, and not merely individual actions (Burnes, 2004). Lastly, Action Research offers the process model as a spiral of planning, action, and fact-finding steps, in line with the CEO’s “Organism” metaphor (Cummings et al., 2016) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020).

3.2. Strengths (Pros): Unfreezing Resistance and Structural Realignment

In terms of its strengths for Wakewood, the framework’s greatest strength lies in its emphasis on thorough “Unfreezing” before any practical implementation due to the significant degree of resistance and lack of digital skills at the unit (MindTools, 2026) (Cummings et al., 2016). Taking into consideration that the process includes both the creation of survival anxiety in

regard to becoming outdated in the market and, conversely, psychological safety due to training, the approach is especially useful for the structural realignments performed by the CEO (Cummings et al., 2016) (Burnes, 2004) (Cameron & Green, 2020). The use of the Force Field Analysis will make the CEO aware that any attempts to add the missing positions will prove futile as long as the general manager's unfreezing is not achieved first (Wakewood Supplies, 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020). The Refreezing step will ensure that these changes stay permanent and are not reverted to their original siloed form when the pressure eases (Cummings et al., 2016) (Al Kuwari et al., 2026).

3.3. Limitations (Disadvantages): “Ice Cube” Paradox and VUCA World

A common limitation of the Lewin change theory among academicians is its association with “ice cube” paradox since, allegedly, it is linearly too simplistic for the VUCA world of 2026, where VUCA means Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity (Cummings et al., 2016). Organizations, according to critics, are continuously transforming and flexible entities, meaning that three stages are too long for a dynamic transformation of intelligent building automation (Fortune Business Insights, 2026) (Burnes, 2004) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026). However, further research shows that Lewin himself described group life as a “live process, something like a river flowing” while maintaining its shape at the same time (Cummings et al., 2016) (Burnes, 2004). The phrase “refreezing,” according to another criticism, implies an unchanging and rigid state; otherwise, it will be the same problem for the general manager as the freezing process itself (Cummings et al., 2016). For 2026, Wakewood will have to rely on Action Research spirals (Cummings et al., 2016) (Cameron & Green, 2020).

3.4. Comparative Analysis: Kotter and ADKAR

To expand analysis into additional frameworks, Lewin's model can be compared to the 8-Step Process from Kotter as well as the ADKAR model (Cummings et al., 2016) (Storm, 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020). While Lewin offers a general framework from psychology, Kotter offers a very specific “Machine-style” step-by-step guide for management (Cameron & Green, 2020). Kotter's approach would give the CEO a much clearer action plan for how to motivate the workers, as Kotter emphasizes “Establishing a Sense of Urgency” (Step 1) and “Communicating the Change Vision” (Step 4), rather than the generic “Unfreeze” approach of Lewin (Cameron & Green, 2020). On the other hand, while Lewin speaks of the “Organism” level, ADKAR (Awareness, Desire, Knowledge, Ability, Reinforcement) is based on individual psychological change (Storm, 2026). The “Desire” and “Ability” components of

ADKAR are key components for Wakewood in order to motivate workers to get past their fears related to AI and other technology (Al Kuwari et al., 2026) (Storm, 2026). The combination of Lewin's diagnostic work and Kotter's guidance for urgency along with ADKAR's approach to individuals helps the unit from its Machine state into an Organism.

4. Conclusions & Constraints

The strategic transformation of Wakewood encounters systematic obstacles based on the GM's "Machine Metaphor," favoring operational cost reductions instead of "Organism" learning (Wakewood Supplies, 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020). The transformation process will be hampered by the GM's possible unwillingness to undergo leadership training to preserve his autocratic position, coupled with financial contexts wherein digital training for 2026 is viewed as unnecessary expenditure (Wakewood Supplies, 2026) (Al Kuwari et al., 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020). These conditions perpetuate "high learning anxiety" in 700 employees, necessitating the establishment of psychological safety to disrupt the dysfunctional system (MindTools, 2026) (Cummings et al., 2016) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026).

In terms of generalizability, some have identified a problem with the "ice cube" fallacy, saying that the model lacks dynamism since its application is not suited to the volatile nature of the Intelligent Building Automation Industry as at 2026 (Fortune Business Insights, 2026) (Cummings et al., 2016). Nevertheless, the model holds up well through "Action Research" spirals (Cummings et al., 2016) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026), which avoids "organizational sclerosis."

In conclusion, the Lewin approach is appropriate since it targets directly at the issue of the "quasi-stationary equilibrium" mentioned by Wakewood in this case (MindTools, 2026) (Cummings et al., 2016) (Wakewood Supplies, 2026). Through the emphasis on "Unfreezing," the CEO will be able to break the balance that exists between the GM and the growth in the market due to the restraining forces by the former (Wakewood Supplies, 2026). This model effectively balances structure with participatory wellness (Alayam News, 2026) (Al Kuwari et al., 2026) (Cameron & Green, 2020).

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